

PTI

BJP'S ON-GROUND STRATEGY

- **Five zones:** Each operational zone with dedicated prabhari for ground execution, troubleshooting and hyper-local adaptation
- **Nightly review:** Closed-door, no-frills meetings where Amit Shah grilled zone heads
- **SOP-driven campaign:** Pre-poll checklists, daily booth-level reporting etc
- **Motorbike rallies:** Held every morning and dusk to reinforce NDA party symbols and candidate recall in remote belts
- **Conduct protocol:** No gutka, no loose talk, no unvetted social media posts

The five-zone grid's feedback proved crucial on two issues—Nitish's resurgent popularity and the need to accelerate spending on women's schemes

and West Champaran); and Mithilanchal. Each zone had a dedicated *pravasi prabhari* (outstation leader) stationed in the region who was tasked with building the organisation and creating a real-time feedback loop that cut through inner party bottlenecks.

The zone divisions were a deliberate re-engineering of the campaign's nervous system. The BJP think-tank realised that Seemanchal's anxieties—shaped by its borderland geography, cross-border migration patterns and minority demography—were fundamentally different from Magadh's agrarian rhythms or Shahabad's caste formations. Treating them as interchangeable, Shah knew, had been a chronic mistake of past campaigns. As one BJP source put it, the five-zone grid ensured the party "responded to political reality rather than to the party's fantasies".

THE VITAL FEEDBACK LOOP

In fact, the network's intervention on two issues proved how crucial it was. They were the first to give feedback that Nitish's popularity was seeing a revival, perhaps the reason why the BJP reversed its initial decision of not backing him as the NDA's chief ministerial candidate. It culminated in Shah's October 29 comment that there is "no vacancy for the post of PM of India and CM of Bihar", which sealed the issue for many voters. In late July, it also flagged the need to accelerate spending on social sector schemes targeting poor women, a direct result of which was the Rs 10,000 direct benefit transfer. Despite its controversial timing, just before the model code of conduct took effect, this proved to be a game-changer, the money in the women's accounts becoming proof of delivery